

Perched on the Pinnacle

The business class still dominates but new challengers are on the rise

They never stop the struggle to protect their power from the ravages of time. Not that success is theirs for ever; still, the relentlessness of their passion and the velocity of their ambition make them stand out from the rest. Their wealth, money or mind, or a combination of both, ensures their elevated place in the social pyramid. They are a privileged minority whose influence is most felt by those who are denied access to their world. They are the power elite. The highest echelon. The classical model of the Establishment—the triangular edifice of the ruling class, the military brass and the business leaders—has already been made redundant by the twin forces of democracy and globalisation. Today the pinstriped gods of the marketplace are the most enduring power peddlers in any free society. The wealth creators top INDIA TODAY Power List 2010, and the durability of their power brings out the survival instincts of the smartest in a world where the infallibility of the so-called Masters of the Universe or the solidity of capitalism are no longer taken for granted. Still, the list mirrors the volatility as well as the versatility of 21st century India where power is not necessarily defined by balance sheets alone. It is reflected in the blockbuster showing in the nearest multiplex, or elsewhere in New York or London. It is being played out in cricket stadiums festooned with the tricolour. It is there in the arguments of the boldest and the brightest in the arena of ideas. And it resonates in the gospels of gurus and yogis. The rapidity with which power updates its list of brand ambassadors only shows the spirit of a country where dreams are getting bigger and bigger. Have a glimpse of them in the following pages.

by S. Prasannarajan



RATAN TATA 72, Industrialist (1)

World Class

Because he commands the unquestioned attention of governments and corporates though he does not figure in any list of Indian billionaires.

Becausehe heads India's largest corporate house, with group revenues expected to cross \$5 billion and the largest market capitalisation of Rs 3,36,450 crore.

Becausehe is constantly thinking of consumers at the bottom of the pyramid, whether it is offering a cellphone call for a paisa per second, the Nano at Rs 1,00,000, low-cost housing at Rs 4 lakh a flat or even a brand-new water purifier at Rs 999.

BecauseTata Tea is the world's largest tea company, TCS is Asia's largest software exporter, Titan is the world's fifth largest watch maker, Tata Steel is the world's sixth largest steel producer and Tata Power

is India's largest private sector power utility.

Becauseunheeding of the Cassandras, he turned around his \$2.3-billion acquisition, Jaguar-Land Rover.

Becausethrough new buys and new products, he has transformed the Tata Group from a collection of companies into a global entity with over 60 per cent revenues coming from its international operations.

Is proud ofHis company's social initiatives, whether it is TCS' functional literacy programme or Tata Teleservices' high-tech help for fishermen.

What's in his garage?A canary yellow Nano, sharing space with a Ferrari and a Lamborghini. But he often drives to work in an Indica.

As good as it getsThe times spent in his Alibaug cottage with his dog, Tito.